

After the Door Closed

There was a year when something in my life stopped.

Nothing outside changed. The same people were there. The same rooms. The same streets. The same days. But my way of moving through them collapsed.

I became someone difficult to be around. Not because I wanted to hurt anyone, but because I no longer knew how to exist among people. Others tried to help me. They spoke, advised, stayed close, and tried to repair what they could see. But the part of me that had broken did not feel reachable anymore.

At some point, I thought escape might be the answer.

Escape from places. Escape from people. *Escape* from thoughts.

But even escape requires movement.

And I *did not move*.

I stayed in the same place, surrounded by the same objects, unable to leave what was happening inside me. It felt less like being trapped in a dangerous place, and more like being trapped inside the same ordinary life with a different way of seeing it.

There was no clear exit. No door. No key. Only repetition. Only the same world, seen through something that had already changed.

The place I lived in Istanbul for more than ten years slowly stopped feeling like home. It was still the same apartment. The walls had not moved. The streets were still there. The small market still opened its door every day. People still walked outside. Cars still passed. Life continued in the same rhythm.

But I could no longer recognize it in the same way.

A place that once felt familiar began to feel heavy. Not suddenly, and not dramatically. It happened *slowly*. The rooms became harder to stay in. The street I used to walk through became harder to cross. The market where I used to buy simple things no longer felt like a normal market. It still sold bread, water, and daily needs, but to me it felt empty.

It felt like it was selling *emptiness*.

Even the people around me seemed different. Or maybe I had changed so much that I could only see myself reflected in their eyes. I felt that my face had become readable, as if people could notice something in me before I said anything. The neighbourhood itself seemed quieter. The street lost its sound. The familiar movements disappeared.

At some point, it no longer felt like I was living in the same world.

Not because the world had changed, but because it had become impossible *to reach*.

Everything remained where it was. The same walls. The same streets. The same objects.

But they *stopped responding*.

It was as if the world had continued without me, and I was left behind inside a version of it that no longer opened. The problem was not that things were disappearing. The problem was that they were staying. Unchanged. Unmoving. Unaffected. While something in me had already crossed a line I could not return from.

This is where the idea of this project began.

The world was not destroyed. The room was not destroyed. The street was not destroyed. The market was not destroyed. But my connection to them was damaged.

This project comes from that experience: the moment when the familiar world remains physically present but no longer feels emotionally close. It tries to show what happens when reality stays in place, but the feeling attached to it changes. The same objects remain in front of us, but they no longer carry the same life.

That is the core of *After the Door Closed*.

The project is not about changing the world itself. It is about showing how loss changes the way the world is seen. A room can remain a room. A chair can remain a chair. A market can remain a market. But after a certain kind of loss, these things no longer reach us in the same way.

I chose to make this project as a web experience because I wanted it to feel immediate and personal. A website is not something the viewer only watches from a distance. It asks the user to write a simple moment. It allows that moment to become part of the artwork.

This was important to me because loss does not only appear in large dramatic moments. It often appears inside *small ordinary moments*: a cup on a table, a chair in a room, a door that *remains closed*, a street that used to feel normal. These things are not dramatic by themselves, but after loss they can become heavy. They can hold memories, absence, and feelings that are difficult to explain directly.

For that reason, I did not want to create a traditional video or a fixed image. A fixed artwork would show only my own experience. This project needed space for the *viewer's own memory*.

The user writes a simple sentence, and the system generates two versions of the same moment: one before loss and one after loss.

The comparison is the heart of the experience.

The before version shows the moment with warmth, familiarity, and ordinary life. It should feel open, safe, and alive. The after version shows the same moment with stillness, distance, and absence. It should not feel exaggerated or overly dramatic. I wanted it to feel quiet, because grief is not always loud. Sometimes it appears through one small detail that no one else notices.

The user does not choose only one side. Both versions are shown together. One side shows what the moment used to feel like. The other side shows what it became after something changed.

That is why the project displays them side by side.

One side carries warmth. The other carries absence.

The difference between them is not meant to be extreme. I want the change to be visible through small details. The same object remains, but suddenly

it becomes harder to look at. The same room remains, but it feels colder. The same street remains, but it no longer feels like it belongs to you.

This is why the AI is instructed to focus on objects rather than direct emotions. I do not want the generated text to say, "This person is sad." That would be too easy. Instead, I want the feeling to appear through an object: an unused cup, a chair, a book, a door, a shirt, a cap, or something left exactly where it was.

The object becomes a witness. It does not explain anything. It simply remains.

In this project, AI is not only a tool that produces text. It acts more like a mirror. I give it a small human moment, and it reflects that moment back in two emotional states. But the meaning does not belong only to the machine. The AI generates language, but I direct the rules, the tone, the structure, and the limits.

This control is important because AI can easily become too dramatic. It can use clichés. It can over-explain feelings. It can make pain sound beautiful too quickly. I had to restrict it and guide it toward simple objects, short images, and quiet emotional changes.

The project is inspired by **Knockin' on Heaven's Door**, not because I wanted to illustrate the song directly, but because the song carries the feeling of standing near a threshold. A door can suggest an ending. It can suggest separation. It can suggest another side that cannot be reached.

In my project, the door is not only a physical object. It represents the boundary between before and after. It is the moment after which the world continues, but the person inside it does not continue in the same way.

After the door closed, the question was not only what was on the other side.

The question was why this side no longer felt like anything at all.

My door is the moment after loss, when the world still exists but no longer feels available. It is the apartment that remains physically present, but no longer feels like home. It is the street that still leads somewhere, but no longer feels like movement. It is the market that still sells ordinary things, but feels emptied of life.

After loss, I could not simply continue as the same person. I was still in the same world, but I could no longer wear the same emotional face.

That is why the project avoids large explanations. It does not try to solve grief. It does not offer healing as a clean ending. Instead, it stays inside the unresolved state. It shows two versions of the same moment and lets the viewer feel the difference.

The goal is not to say, “This is what loss means.” The goal is to ask: why does the same thing feel different now?

In that sense, **After the Door Closed** is not only about my own experience. It begins from my life, but it tries to reach something more general. Everyone has a moment when the world becomes divided into before and after. Everyone has objects that carry more than they should. Everyone has rooms, streets, or ordinary places that remember what people cannot say.

The artwork asks the viewer to write a simple moment and then watch it change. The same sentence becomes two perceptions. The same world becomes two worlds.

And the door remains between them.

The door is not opened in this project. It is not solved. It is not explained. It is simply there, separating what was from what remains.

This is why the project matters to me. It allowed me to take something that felt impossible to explain and turn it into an experience. It gave shape to something that had no shape. It helped me understand that art does not always remove pain, but it can make pain visible enough to be held for a moment.

The world did not change.

I did.

And after the door closed, I had to learn how to see again.